

TOILET TRAINING

Sanitation became an issue of concern at the World Toilet Organisation summit and many experts stepped forward to tackle deteriorating sanitary conditions and the recycling of waste



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■ By Priya Sahgal

A globe-trotting Kamal Nath may think he has all the answers but even he will be flummoxed by this one. Last week 175 foreign delegates from 45 countries came to Delhi for a meeting of er...the World Toilet Organisation (wro). The capital was draped with banners advertising the event with all the fanfare of a nuclear seminar. And it could well have been, with the Prince of Netherlands, a former President of India and three Union ministers addressing the summit. The world of acronyms just got curiouser and curiouser.

"Domestic hygiene is regarded as dirty and people don't want to talk about it, so it lags behind. But what impressed me about India is that there seems to be a lively debate on sanitation. Getting a former President to address the summit is a big deal," said Jack Sim, who refers to himself as the

Toiletman and who established the toilet organisation in 2001. The aim is to "walk the last mile in sanitation". Interestingly, Kolkata was the third city in the world after London and New York to have a sewage system in 1870. Yet in 137 years, only 232 of the 5,000 towns in India are connected to the sewage system. As for the villages, toilets are a luxury few can afford, let alone sewer lines.

Yet, as Jack noticed, there are quite a few in India who want to change the way the country defecates. Bindeshwar Pathak, a co-sponsor of the event and founder of the Sulabh sanitation movement has set up the world's first toilet museum in India. "This is to encourage an awareness about sanitation," he says. When Pathak first decided

POTTY BUSINESS: Displays at the summit (above); European urinals

to set up this museum in Delhi he wrote to the embassies of various countries seeking their opinion on it. As many as 56 countries wrote back affirming the idea but US objected when Pathak took things to another level and said he would play each country's national anthem at the inauguration ceremony. The museum orchestrates the history of sanitation, displays various kinds of toilet technologies, ranging from the ancient to the bizarre.

The deputy general manager of Chennai Airport, R.P. Hazare, was a recent visitor at the museum simply because he wanted to do something to improve the stench at the Chennai airport. He was particularly impressed with the idea of setting up a bio-gas plant to

